
Networks of Manuscript Production: Mapping Female Scribes and their Texts in Medieval Europe

Estelle Gueville*¹

¹Yale University – United States

Abstract

Manuscripts are networked objects (Stein 2023; Koepke 2025; Fernandez Riva 2019; Serif 2023), yet manuscript studies focusing on scribes have remained surprisingly marginal within historical network research (Kaska, 2023). Although female scribes' contributions remain often invisible in existing scholarship and the sources that describe their work remain uneven, these women were central to the production and circulation of devotional, liturgical, and theological texts across late medieval Europe. This paper argues that network analysis offers a necessary methodological framework for reconstructing women's textual labor as a relational system rather than a collection of disconnected manuscripts or exceptional individuals. Drawing on *Unknown Hands*, the first large-scale dataset dedicated to manuscripts copied by women in Christian Europe before 1600 (Guéville 2026), the corpus currently contains more than 1900 scribal units associated with approximately 1300 manuscripts across over 230 institutions from the eighth to the sixteenth centuries. The data derive from manuscript catalogues, archival descriptions, and codicological and paleographical analysis. It includes multilingual material in Latin and numerous vernacular languages, and records were enriched with temporal, spatial, institutional, and genre metadata in order to model relationships between scribes, manuscripts, texts, genres, and conventual houses.

This paper reconstructs and analyzes networks of textual production copied by women using bipartite network analysis to three interconnected layers: scribes, manuscripts, and institutions with genres and subgenres. Rather than reducing the corpus to manuscript-to-manuscript projections, this approach preserves the distinct roles of people, books, and institutions within systems of textual production and circulation (Koepke 2025). The analysis combines network visualization with measures of connectivity, brokerage, and core-periphery structure in order to identify hubs, bridges, and peripheral clusters within women's textual culture.

Preliminary results suggest that certain texts act as major connective hubs, copied in multiple institutions, revealing shared repertoires across female houses which reflect shared literacy and devotional cultures. Across all three analytical layers, the same structural pattern emerges: a highly centralized religious core—with main liturgical, devotional, scriptural and theological subgenres clusters linking most scribes, manuscripts, and institutions—surrounded by weakly connected peripheral domains. Other genres—literary, historical, educational, scientific, legal, or administrative—circulate far more unevenly and depend disproportionately on a small number of brokers.

*Speaker

At the level of individual scribes, a few figures such as Diemut (Beach, 2004), Margarete Kartäuserin, Clara Hätzlerin (Edmunds, 1999), Cordula von Schönau, and Kunigund Niklasin (Poor, 2026) function as brokers, occupying structurally exceptional positions connecting several subgenres, and often otherwise weakly related textual domains. Yet, other textual genres and subgenres remain highly localized, linked to a single scribe and religious house and its specific devotional practices and individual agency. Institutionally, houses such as the Katharinenkloster in Nuremberg, Medingen, and Santa Brigida del Paradiso emerge as major hubs stabilizing and disseminating shared textual traditions. More broadly, the paper argues that network analysis can move manuscript studies beyond isolated codices toward comparative, large-scale models of textual circulation, collaboration, and institutional exchange to transform how we understand medieval literary culture, knowledge transmission, and scribal practices.

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Keywords: Female scribes, manuscripts, women's agency, gender studies, manuscripts networks

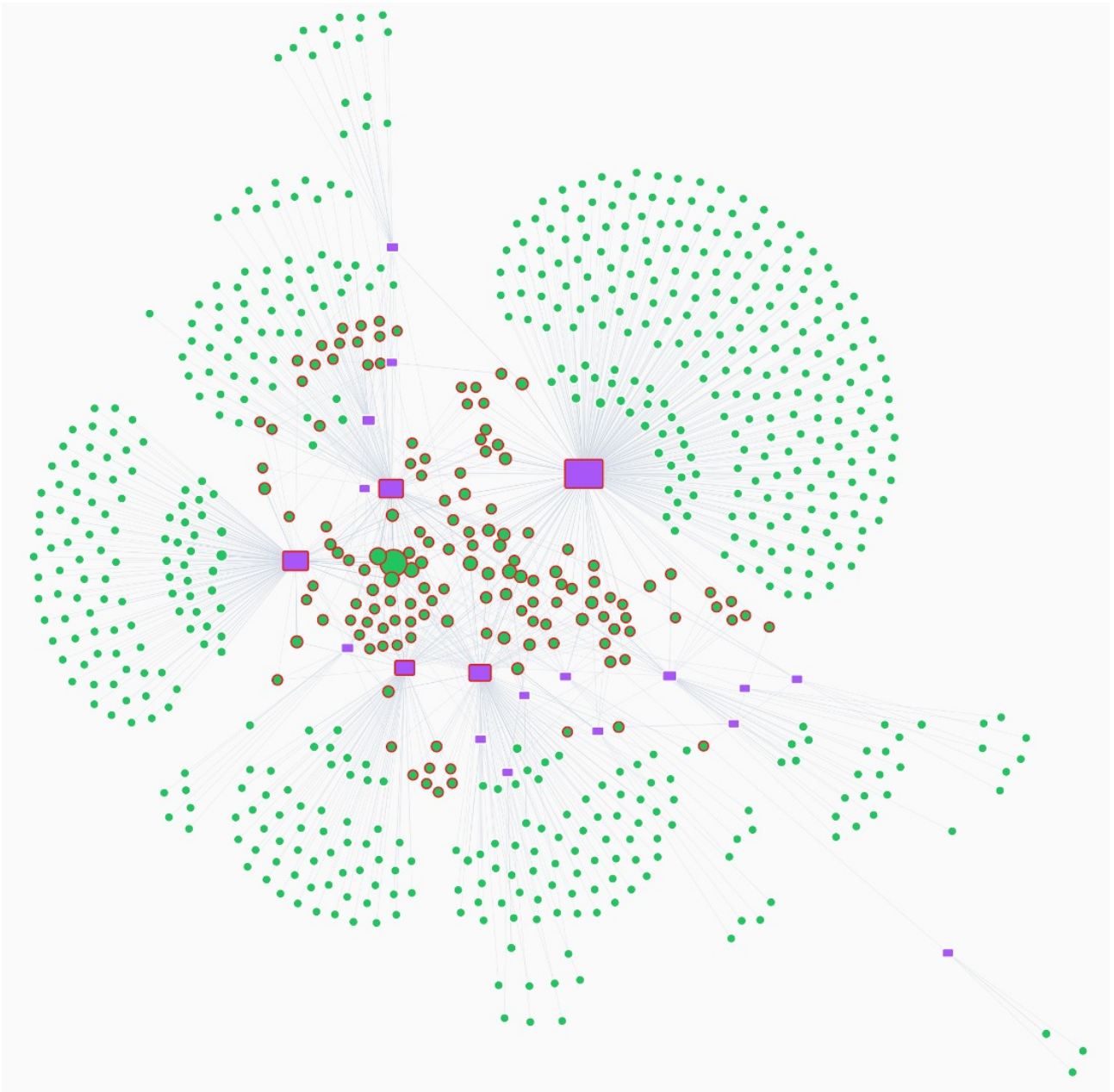


Figure 1: Bipartite network of female scribes and the textual subgenres they copied. Green circles represent scribes and purple rectangles represent subgenres; edges connect scribes to the subgenres attested in their manuscripts. The visualization highlights both highly central subgenres copied by many women and more specialized clusters associated with smaller groups of scribes.